

# SuryaPass: an AI inspection copilot for India's rooftop-solar installers

The best pivot for a one-week university/incubator pitch competition, the runners-up, a 12-slide deck outline and a 7-day plan.

**Recommendation.** Pivot Screwge into **SuryaPass**: an AI pre-inspection and compliance-pack tool for PM Surya Ghar rooftop-solar vendors. It checks installation photos, serial numbers and paperwork against MNRE/DISCOM rules *before* upload, so vendors pass inspection the first time, get the subsidy released and stay active on the portal.

## Why it beat the other 11 ideas

| Test                            | How SuryaPass scores                                                                                                                                                                |
|---------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Payer is the beneficiary</b> | The vendor who pays is the one who gains (faster subsidy, fewer revisits, portal access protected). This fixes the core flaw of Screwge v1, where GCs gain from paying subs slowly. |
| <b>Sharp why-now</b>            | MNRE tightened enforcement in 2026: serial-number blocking (May), a vendor-violation SOP (June), nearly 23,000 third-party inspections, 66 vendors deactivated (Aug).               |
| <b>Founder fit</b>              | Your father's solar business, Tamil and Hindi, and Screwge's existing evidence engine.                                                                                              |
| <b>Demo in a week</b>           | A working pre-check on real rooftop photos is realistic in 7 days.                                                                                                                  |
| <b>Open gap</b>                 | No startup was found selling AI photo checks for this workflow. Tata Power had to build its own (22+ AI checks).                                                                    |

## Runners-up

- **QA and handover evidence for mid-size Indian solar builders** (SenseHawk, now Reliance-owned, leads this space).
- **Construction-evidence files for US solar tax credits** (sharp why-now, but the rules keep changing).
- **Proof-of-delivery for Indian transporters** (strong fit through the family fleet, but crowded).

Main risks: the scheme's current period ends 31 March 2027 and an extension isn't guaranteed; MNRE could add AI checks to the portal itself; small vendors are very price-sensitive. Pricing and market sizes in this report are hypotheses to test, not findings.

## SECTION A

### All 12 candidates, ranked

| #  | Idea                                                                                                                       | Market | Crowdedness             | Founder fit | 1-week demo | Verdict                       |
|----|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------|-------------------------|-------------|-------------|-------------------------------|
| 1  | <b>SuryaPass:</b> AI pre-inspection + subsidy/compliance pack for PM Surya Ghar vendors (later: 5-yr maintenance evidence) | India  | Low-medium              | Very high   | High        | <b>Recommended</b>            |
| 2  | QA/NCR/handover evidence for mid-size utility-scale and C&I solar EPCs                                                     | India  | Medium-high (SenseHawk) | High        | Medium      | Backup / phase 2              |
| 3  | "Continuity file" for US solar/wind tax credits (45Y/48E audit evidence)                                                   | US     | Low for software        | Medium      | Medium      | US alternative; policy risk   |
| 4  | Proof-of-delivery-to-payment evidence for mid-size transporters                                                            | India  | High                    | Very high   | High        | Viable, hard to differentiate |
| 5  | PM-KUSUM feeder / Component-A plant QA                                                                                     | India  | Low                     | High        | Low         | Expansion lane for #1         |
| 6  | Data center MEP commissioning/handover evidence                                                                            | India  | Medium                  | Medium      | Low         | Later                         |
| 7  | NCR + change order + RA bill in one flow for Indian GCs                                                                    | India  | Medium                  | Medium      | High        | Thin gap                      |
| 8  | Verified-work financing for subcontractors                                                                                 | India  | High                    | Medium      | Low         | Avoid for now                 |
| 9  | Construction lender draw verification                                                                                      | US     | Very high               | Low         | Medium      | Avoid                         |
| 10 | Discom/PPA payment-delay tooling                                                                                           | India  | Problem largely solved  | High        | Medium      | Avoid                         |
| 11 | Owner-side project memory / closeout                                                                                       | US     | Very high               | Medium      | High        | Avoid                         |
| 12 | Rooftop-solar installer CRM/proposal software                                                                              | India  | Very high               | High        | High        | Avoid (partner instead)       |

### Why some obvious ideas fail

- **Draw verification:** Built Technologies already serves ~185,000 contractors with lenders like U.S. Bank and Citi and markets an AI Draw Agent; Sitewire added BudgetIQ/PermitIQ in December 2025.
- **Discom payment delays:** legacy dues fell from ₹1,39,947 crore (June 2022) to ₹3,330 crore (27 March 2026) under the Late Payment Surcharge Rules.
- **Project memory and installer CRMs:** already crowded (Procore/Datagrid, Trunk Tools, Kahua, Newforma; Solar Ladder, QuickEstimate, Arka360, SurgePV).

## SECTION B

# The top ideas in detail

## 1. SuryaPass: AI pre-inspection and compliance pack (India) — recommended

*"An AI inspector in every rooftop installer's pocket: pass the DISCOM and third-party inspection first time, get the subsidy released, and never get deactivated."*

### THE PROBLEM

- **Scale:** as of 4 Aug 2026, PM Surya Ghar had benefited 50.06 lakh households, commissioned 14.8 GW and released ₹28,024 crore via DBT. July 2026 alone saw 5.06 lakh household installations (~16,328/day, up from ~5,038/day in Oct 2025). PIB reported 65+ lakh applications in the pipeline.
- **Fragmented supply:** 34,219 registered vendors, 29,469 active. TechCrunch calls the market "highly fragmented, dominated by small local installers and dealer networks."
- **Enforcement tightened in 2026:** repeated module serial numbers blocked from 26 May; a vendor-violation SOP (22 June) covering defects in modules, inverters, structures, earthing, cables and documentation, with 8 days to respond and one-month deactivation; nearly 23,000 third-party inspections; 66 vendors deactivated in August over pending applications; new branding-sticker rules (Aug) and mandatory consumer approval (Sept).
- **Money at stake per job:** subsidy up to ₹78,000 for a 3 kW system. Non-ALMM/DCR modules found at inspection can mean rejection, and vendors quoting net-of-subsidy carry the delay risk. An older Reuters snapshot found close to 60% of applications pending and ~7% rejected, often for incomplete documents.
- **Proof at the top of the market:** Tata Power built its own AI inspection system (22+ checks across six components), cutting turnaround "from two days to 10 minutes," repeat visits by 80%+ and manual inspection cost by 96%. The other ~29,000 vendors can't build this themselves.

### WARNING SIGN

- Applications stuck at "inspection pending" or sent back for blurry or missing photos; repeat site visits for earthing, surge protection or labelling; serial-number flags; subsidy not credited 60–90+ days after commissioning; vendor names on the deactivation list.

### HOW TO PROVE IT IN ONE WEEK

- **Fork Screwge's evidence flow** into a ~20-check rooftop template: ALMM/DCR label and module serial OCR with duplicate check, inverter serial, structure and anchoring, earthing, SPD/ACDB/DCDB, cable routing, net meter, PMSG sticker, geo-tag and timestamp. Output: pass / fix-before-upload plus a one-tap PDF inspection pack.
- **Collect 100+ real photo sets** from your father's network and 3–5 Chennai/Coimbatore installers. Have an electrical engineer label them and report AI-vs-engineer agreement (e.g., "caught 17 of 20 real defects").
- **Run 15–20 vendor interviews**, at least half outside family networks. Ask for rejection/revisit rate and days-to-subsidy.
- **Close 3–5 paid pilots** (e.g., ₹999 for the first 20 installs) or signed LOIs from non-family vendors.

### BUYERS

- **Primary: mid-size empanelled vendors** (~30–500 installs/month). They pay and they benefit: fewer revisits, faster subsidy and loan release, protected portal access.

- **Channel: OEM brands with dealer networks** (Tata Power, Waaree, Luminous, Exide) that want dealer quality and brand protection.
- **Later:** lenders that need proof of the asset before disbursing, and inspection agencies that could triage remotely.

#### COMPETITORS AND YOUR EDGE

- **Solar Ladder** (~\$1M seed; claims 700+ EPCs) and **QuickEstimate** (claims 1,000+ EPCs): design, CRM, subsidy calculators. No AI inspection.
- **Solarlonix:** GPS-stamped stage photos and an audit-ready document pack, but no AI checks. Closest threat.
- **SenseHawk** (Reliance, 79.4% for \$32M): utility-scale, not residential. **AiRotor** drones: ~₹5,000 per site, too expensive per rooftop. **SolarSquare** (\$53M Series C): big enough to build its own.
- **Your edge:** Screwge's capture → AI pre-check → review → payment-ready pipeline maps almost one-to-one; family solar credibility; Tamil/Hindi voice notes for crews; shipping speed. Moat over time: a labelled dataset of Indian rooftop defects plus DISCOM-specific rule libraries.

#### BUSINESS MODEL (HYPOTHESES)

- **Pricing:** ₹149–299 per installation, or ₹2,999–9,999/month tiers. Under 0.4% of the ₹78,000 subsidy at risk.
- **Install lane:** ~5 lakh households/month × ₹200 ≈ ₹10 crore/month ≈ ₹120 crore/yr (~\$14M). An upper bound.
- **Maintenance lane:** ~40 lakh systems installed by 24 July 2026, each with a mandatory 5-year maintenance contract; ₹300/system/yr for service-visit evidence adds a similar amount.
- **Honest read:** residential India alone is ~\$15–30M/yr. Venture scale needs KUSUM (13.11 GW of 34.8 GW target), commercial rooftop and utility-scale QA.

#### RISKS

- **Policy cliff:** the scheme runs to 31 March 2027; MNRE officials project ~85–90 lakh households by then, short of 1 crore. Extension not guaranteed.
- **Government build risk:** MNRE could add AI checks to the portal.
- **Willingness to pay:** small vendors are very price-sensitive.
- **Accuracy liability:** a "pass" that later fails inspection destroys trust.
- **Copycats:** CRMs like Solar Ladder or Solarlonix could add AI quickly. Speed and data are the only moat.

## 2. QA/NCR and handover evidence for mid-size solar EPCs (India)

*"SenseHawk for the 10–200 MW EPC that still runs QA on WhatsApp."*

|                     |                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|---------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Problem</b>      | India added a record 44.6 GW of solar in FY2026 (~34.8 GW ground-mounted, +106% YoY) and ~19 GW of utility-scale in H1 2026. Even the leader says solar data "lives in spreadsheets, ERPs, and WhatsApp threads." |
| <b>Warning sign</b> | Punch lists open after COD; serial mismatches at handover; lender's engineer rejecting progress claims; O&M inheriting incomplete as-builts.                                                                      |
| <b>1-week proof</b> | Load one of your father's plant BOQs and inspection plans into Screwge; capture evidence on a live block; show auto-NCRs and a handover pack; interview 5 EPC QA heads.                                           |
| <b>Buyers</b>       | Developers/IPPs paying for EPC accountability; EPCs wanting faster milestone billing. Beware misalignment when the EPC pays for its own subs.                                                                     |
| <b>Competitors</b>  | SenseHawk (Reliance): 200+ GW, map-based QA/QC with NCRs; drone services (AiRotor, MapperX). Edge: cheap, mobile-first, founder access to real plants. Thin against a Reliance-backed incumbent.                  |
| <b>Model</b>        | ₹1,000–3,000 per MW per month during construction; 40+ GW/yr being built.                                                                                                                                         |
| <b>Risks</b>        | SenseHawk undercuts; long enterprise sales; hard to show a real deployment in a week.                                                                                                                             |

## 3. "Continuity file" for US solar/wind tax credits (US)

*"Audit-proof, timestamped evidence that your project began construction and kept building, so the 45Y/48E credit survives an IRS exam."*

|                     |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|---------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Problem</b>      | Under the OBBBA, projects must have begun construction by 4 July 2026 or be placed in service by 31 Dec 2027, and must keep a "continuous program of construction." Advisors warn documentation "should accumulate in real time, not be reconstructed years later." Credits can be up to 40% of project cost. |
| <b>Warning sign</b> | Developers scrambling for photos and invoices during tax-equity diligence; gaps in work logs during stoppages.                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| <b>1-week proof</b> | A tamper-evident, geo-timestamped "continuity ledger" demo exported as an audit binder; interview 5 tax-equity/accounting professionals via USC Marshall alumni.                                                                                                                                              |
| <b>Buyers</b>       | Developers and tax-equity investors (both lose if the credit fails).                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| <b>Competitors</b>  | Served today as a service by advisory firms (Baker Tilly, CohnReznick, CLA, Fallbrook). Edge: finance + evidence tech. Weakness: no US developer network.                                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>Model</b>        | \$5k–20k per project per year (to validate).                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| <b>Risks</b>        | Rules in flux (a June 2026 court ruling vacated Notice 2025-42 for now); the new-start window has closed, so it's a finite cohort; buyers may prefer their accountants.                                                                                                                                       |

## 4. Proof-of-delivery-to-payment for Indian transporters (India)

"Turn every delivery into a verified, dispute-proof POD pack so fleets get freight bills cleared in days, not months."

|                     |                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|---------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Problem</b>      | Shippers won't clear freight bills until they get a valid POD; delays and deductions starve fleets paying daily fuel, tolls and EMIs. (Sources are industry blogs; validate with Shriniwasa Roadways' own receivable days.) |
| <b>Warning sign</b> | High DSO; deductions for shortage or damage without evidence; lost paper PODs.                                                                                                                                              |
| <b>1-week proof</b> | Run on 30 Shriniwasa trips: driver WhatsApp photo/voice → AI-verified POD pack; measure days-to-payment vs baseline.                                                                                                        |
| <b>Buyers</b>       | Fleet owners (aligned); shippers benefit from fewer disputes.                                                                                                                                                               |
| <b>Competitors</b>  | TrucksUp (\$8.2M raised, 2026), free government ULIP tools, legacy aggregators; >\$500M invested in Indian trucking tech since 2014. Edge: family fleet as design partner.                                                  |
| <b>Model</b>        | ₹20–50 per trip, or an invoice-discounting partnership.                                                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>Risks</b>        | Low willingness to pay; shippers control the process; crowded.                                                                                                                                                              |

### SECTION C

## The recommended pivot: SuryaPass by Screwge

**Positioning line:** "Pass the solar inspection the first time."

Alternates: "The quality layer for India's rooftop solar boom." Keep **Screwge** as the company and use **SuryaPass** as the product.

### Why it wins a university/incubator competition

- **Official data judges trust:** PIB/MNRE numbers, a named SOP, 66 deactivated vendors, nearly 23,000 inspections.
- **Aligned incentives:** directly answers the flaw you discovered in Screwge v1.
- **Sharp why-now:** 16,000+ installs/day, tightened 2026 enforcement, and a March 2027 deadline rush.
- **Founder-market fit judges can feel:** "My father develops solar plants; I speak Tamil and Hindi to installers; I've already built the evidence engine."
- **Live demo:** upload a rooftop photo and watch it flag a missing earthing strap or a duplicate serial.
- **Credible validation in a week** from non-family vendors, and a growth path beyond the scheme (maintenance evidence → KUSUM → utility-scale).

## 12-slide deck outline

| #  | Slide               | Key message / data                                                                                                                 |
|----|---------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1  | Title               | SuryaPass by Screwge. "Pass the solar inspection the first time." Founders, USC Marshall + Vanderbilt.                             |
| 2  | The boom            | 50.06 lakh households, 14.8 GW, ₹28,024 crore subsidy released (Aug 2026); 16,328 installs/day in July 2026.                       |
| 3  | The crackdown       | Serial blocking (May), vendor-violation SOP (June), ~23,000 inspections, 66 vendors deactivated (Aug 2026).                        |
| 4  | Pain for one vendor | Up to ₹78,000 subsidy at stake per 3 kW job; revisits, rejections, cash stuck. Add a quote and a number from your interviews.      |
| 5  | Why it's unsolved   | Tata Power built 22+ AI checks in-house; ~29,000 other vendors can't. CRMs don't verify evidence.                                  |
| 6  | Product demo        | Capture → AI pre-check (fix-before-upload) → inspection pack → maintenance evidence. Live or 60-sec video.                         |
| 7  | Proof it works      | AI-vs-engineer accuracy on 100+ real photo sets; time saved per job.                                                               |
| 8  | Validation          | X vendor interviews, Y paid pilots/LOIs (state how many are non-family), quotes.                                                   |
| 9  | Business model      | ₹149–299/install or monthly tiers; OEM dealer channel; ~₹120 crore/yr install lane + maintenance lane.                             |
| 10 | Competition         | 2×2: AI verification × small-vendor focus. Solar Ladder/QuickEstimate/Solarlonix, SenseHawk, Tata in-house, drones.                |
| 11 | Pivot story + team  | "110 construction interviews taught us GCs profit from delaying sub payments, so we took the same engine where the payer wins."    |
| 12 | Roadmap + ask       | Q4 2026 TN/Gujarat vendors → Q1 2027 OEM channel + maintenance → KUSUM/C&I/utility. Ask: prize, incubator seat, DISCOM/OEM intros. |

## How to present Screwge's traction honestly

- Call the 110 interviews "customer discovery that killed our first thesis."
- Present the TestFlight MVP and pilot sites as "the engine we reused."
- Disclose that the earlier LOIs came from family-connected contractors, and show that the new ones don't.
- Never present the construction LOIs as SuryaPass traction.

## SECTION D

### 7-day plan: idea to finished deck

| Day   | What to do                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|-------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Day 1 | Lock the thesis. Turn the MNRE SOP, serial/DCR rules and one state DISCOM inspection checklist into a rule list. Ask your father's network and USC/Chennai contacts for 10 installer intros. Start collecting 100+ photo sets, including known-bad ones. |
| Day 2 | Fork Screwge: checklist template, serial OCR + duplicate check, AI pre-check prompts per component, PDF pack. 6-8 vendor calls: rejection rate, revisit cost, days-to-subsidy, what they'd pay.                                                          |
| Day 3 | Run the AI on labelled photos and compute accuracy. 6-8 more calls, including Gujarat/Maharashtra. Call one DISCOM or third-party inspection engineer: "what fails most?"                                                                                |
| Day 4 | On-site pilot with 1-2 Chennai installers (co-founder or family can run it). Time a job with and without SuryaPass. Ask for a paid pilot or LOI.                                                                                                         |
| Day 5 | Talk to one OEM dealer manager (Tata Power Solar/Waaree) about channel pricing. Get story feedback from Prof. Vasquez and one investor. Build the market-sizing model.                                                                                   |
| Day 6 | Build the 12-slide deck. Record a 60-second demo video as backup.                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| Day 7 | Two timed rehearsals. Prep answers for: the March 2027 cliff, portal build risk, Solar Ladder adding AI, willingness to pay, accuracy liability.                                                                                                         |

#### Caveats

- Several PMSG figures come from reprints of MNRE/PIB releases (ANI, Business Standard) rather than the originals. Households benefited (~48 lakh) is higher than systems installed (~40 lakh) as of 24 July 2026, so don't mix the units on slides.
- No published defect rates from the ~23,000 third-party inspections were found. Your own photo audit becomes original data; label it as such.
- The Reuters "~60% pending, ~7% rejected" figures are an older snapshot; competitor customer counts are company claims.
- The scheme's current period ends 31 March 2027; treat any extension as speculative until MNRE announces it.
- US tax-credit rules (idea 3) were changing as of mid-2026; get a tax professional's review before relying on them.
- Pricing and market sizes are hypotheses to validate this week, not findings.

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